

# Escaping the State of Nature: Hobbes's Case for the Sovereign

An original lesson plan inspired by **Thomas Hobbes's** *Leviathan* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or Thomas Hobbes. Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/3207>

| GRADE LEVEL                  | DURATION   | TOPICS               |
|------------------------------|------------|----------------------|
| Grades 11-12 / Intro College | 60 minutes | Political Philosophy |

*“Hobbes argues that life without government is 'solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and short' — is he right that only an absolute, unquestionable sovereign can save us from that condition?”*

## Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Hobbes's account of the state of nature and why he thinks it inevitably leads to a 'war of every man against every man.'
- Trace Hobbes's argument from the state of nature, through the laws of nature, to the social contract that creates the sovereign.
- Evaluate Hobbes's claim that the sovereign's power must be absolute and nearly unlimited to secure peace, and identify the strongest objection to it.

## Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Excerpt handout: *Leviathan*, Part I, Chapter 13 (the state of nature) and Chapter 17 (the generation of the commonwealth)
- Case-study scenario describing a sudden, total breakdown of law and government for 48 hours
- Graphic organizer: state of nature → laws of nature → social contract → sovereign

## Lesson Procedure

### Hook: No Government for 48 Hours

8 min

Pose the scenario: all law enforcement, courts, and government suddenly vanish in your town for 48 hours. Ask students to predict, individually and then aloud, what they think would actually happen and why, and record predictions on the board.

**Direct Instruction: The State of Nature and the War of All Against All**

18 min

Present Hobbes's state of nature: rough equality among humans means no one is ever fully safe from anyone else, and scarcity, distrust, and the desire for reputation produce a condition of war even without constant fighting, since the disposition to contend is enough. Introduce Hobbes's argument that reason discovers 'laws of nature,' such as seeking peace and laying down one's unlimited right to all things, which point the way out of this condition.

**Small-Group Reading**

16 min

In groups, students read the assigned excerpt on the social contract (Chapter 17) and identify what right individuals give up, to whom, and why Hobbes thinks the sovereign's power must be near-absolute, undivided, and irrevocable in order to actually keep the peace rather than collapsing back into conflict.

**Whole-Class Debate**

12 min

Debate whether Hobbes's argument really requires an absolute sovereign to escape the state of nature, or whether a weaker, internally checked government could secure peace just as effectively.

**Closure**

6 min

Return to the '48 hours without government' predictions from the hook and connect them explicitly to Hobbes's state-of-nature argument, asking whether students' predictions support or challenge his view of human nature.

**Discussion Questions**

- 1 Is Hobbes right that even roughly equal, otherwise decent people would descend into a 'war of all against all' without a common power to keep them in awe, or does this underestimate cooperation, trust, and social norms?
- 2 Hobbes argues the sovereign's power must be absolute and essentially unaccountable to prevent a slide back into civil war. Does the history of unchecked governments support or undermine that argument?
- 3 If the sovereign fails at its one job of protecting subjects, does Hobbes's own logic allow subjects to resist or replace it, or does his theory leave no room for legitimate rebellion?
- 4 Is the social contract in Leviathan a historical claim, that societies were literally founded this way, or a hypothetical justificatory device explaining why we ought to obey regardless of history? Does it matter which?
- 5 What does Hobbes's account assume about human nature: are people fundamentally self-interested and competitive, or does his state of nature already assume the breakdown of any cooperative instincts?

**Assessment**

Students write a short essay evaluating whether a specific, real historical case of state collapse or civil breakdown (which you may assign or let them research) supports or challenges Hobbes's claim that only an absolute sovereign can prevent a slide into a 'war of all against all.'

**Extension Activity**



Have students research one historical or contemporary example of a 'failed state' or an extended period without effective government, and write a short analysis comparing what actually happened to Hobbes's predictions about the state of nature.

---

Free to use, adapt, and share for educational purposes with attribution to Philosophy Commons. This lesson plan is an original work created by Philosophy Commons; it is inspired by, but is not a reproduction of, the credited course's actual materials.